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The Emperor’s Voice

PLUNGING ASHOKA INTO AN EMOTIONAL CRISIS, THE result of the Kalinga war radically redirected the entire subsequent life and career of the grieving conqueror. The personal upheaval was also, inadvertently perhaps, a powerful and new political idea: by replacing subjugation with compassion as the most fundamental principle of monarchy, it introduced the earliest glimmerings of a rule of law in which ordinary folk and the citizenry, rather than only the powerful elites and royalty, were consequential. If one were for a moment to visualize the scenario symbolically, as a single image, it could take the shape of Ashoka calling for a copy of the *Arthashastra* and setting it on fire in full public view. A new perception of kingly calling emerged out of this victory-as-defeat, one which Ashoka touched upon some years later when describing how he discharged his royal responsibilities and duties over this part of his reign. Central in his narrative in the aftermath of securing territorial supremacy was the contrast between his conduct and that of earlier kings. Ashoka’s self-understanding and how he chose to arrange his narrative of kingship are therefore crucial to any account of his reign.

It was a little after 260 BCE when Ashoka sent out a communiqué to his administrators in various parts of India—from the edge of the Yamuna flood plain in North India to the castellated hills of Karnataka in the South.[1] To distinguish it from the more expansive later edicts on rocks that are known as his ‘major rock edicts’, this communiqué has been classified among his minor rock edicts.[2] Actually, when Ashoka decided to disseminate his words in this way he did not (or possibly could not) bring himself to